

6, The Monumental Significance of The Great Expansion in the Formation of Classical Empires

First, **The Great Expansion** shielded society from plunging into the **Malthusian Trap** (马尔萨斯陷阱), ensuring the steady growth of labor productivity (劳动生产率). This was its most paramount economic contribution.

Before metal tools were widely utilized, the inhabitants of the civilized world were akin to being stranded on isolated islands amidst a boundless ocean. The city-states capable of stably providing various surplus products remained phenomenally static for millennia. The boundaries of their "fertile fields and beautiful ponds" (良田美池) were perceived by generation after generation as immutably fixed.

This is not to say that prior to the Great Expansion, early civilizations possessed absolutely zero capacity to transform nature and expand agricultural land; the ancient Egyptians were constantly attempting to develop the Faiyum Oasis (法尤姆绿洲). But such development clearly amounted to mere piecemeal tinkering on the fringes of their original geographical units. It neither altered the geopolitical paradigm facing their civilization, nor was it sufficient to effectively relieve demographic pressure.

Both Mesopotamia and Egypt endured more than one catastrophically destructive societal crisis long before losing their independence in the final epoch before the Common Era—such as the First Intermediate Period of Egypt. As for Mesopotamia, its agricultural economic conditions had already severely degraded during the late Sumerian period, plagued by atrocious soil salinization (土地盐碱化). An even more tragic case is the Indus Valley Civilization, which completely vanished even before the Aryans arrived; its cities were abandoned, highly likely due to severe environmental degradation.

The inhabitants of these "isolated islands" were not entirely unable to flee. They naturally had the opportunity to defect and join the surrounding tribes, but doing so would mean they were no longer regarded as members of the civilized world.

As Thomas Malthus asserted, until the advent of modern science and the onset of the Industrial Revolution, technological progress occurred only sporadically; the productive forces fundamentally would not experience the kind of explosive growth witnessed over the past two-plus centuries. Yet, given sufficient resources, populations will inevitably grow exponentially. **This signifies that any sporadic improvement in productive forces will inevitably be neutralized by population growth!** Society thus plunges into a state characterized in recent years as "**involution**" (内卷): labor productivity fundamentally cannot increase substantially, the living standards of societal members see no improvement, and sometimes they even deteriorate further!

The Great Expansion terminated this existential peril for several centuries!

For those ethnic groups that participated in this historical process, the moment the society generated surplus population, or when regional agricultural crises erupted due to climate shifts, this "surplus population" could seek survival by migrating far away to pioneer new frontiers of the civilized world. Advancements in social production were no longer neutralized by population growth! After all, as long as they had a choice, what reason would people who had tasted a better life have to return to more miserable conditions?

In fact, if one notes how the ancient Greeks used to cast lots among families with multiple sons to send one son away to a colony, it is effortless to grasp the monumental significance of the Great Expansion in relieving demographic pressure. During this specific era, population growth was actually an immense blessing! The size of the population perfectly dictated the sheer magnitude of the territories they could pioneer, without the slightest fear of diminishing agricultural returns or plummeting living standards.

The population mobility and explosive demographic growth brought about by this expansion—coupled with the collisions and exchanges among ethnic groups and the discovery of new resource origins—all possessed the potential to violently stimulate commercial activities, making them phenomenally prosperous. Moreover, they provided an immensely positive impetus for technological innovation.

It was precisely this slow yet persistently steady growth in labor productivity during the centuries preceding the establishment of classical empires that laid the bedrock for classical prosperity! The immense accumulation of social wealth created vastly more **non-productive intellectuals** (脱产知识分子) than existed prior to the expansion. This catalyzed a massive eruption of revolutionary new philosophies, new sciences, and new technologies, forging the indispensable prerequisites for the formation of vastly more complex state apparatuses!

This rapid expansionary process, however, did not continue indefinitely. From the moment classical empires expanded to their maximum frontiers until the dawn of the **High Middle Ages** (*in my narrative, I equate the Middle Ages with the **feudal period**, and the High Middle Ages with the **mid-feudalization stage***), although land reclamation never entirely ceased during these centuries, its efficiency fundamentally could not rival the expansion during the formative period of **classical society**. This was due to the rapid development of a **natural economy** (自然经济) and the deliberate weakening of centralized political organizational capacity (*which, naturally, was absolutely not a bad thing*).

Demographic fluctuations (*which inherently reflect the total acreage of cultivated land behind that population*) amply demonstrate this reality. Between 150 AD and 1000 AD, whether in Europe undergoing normal **feudalization** or in China, which ultimately completed its **bureaucratic restoration** (*let us ignore the tragic, catastrophic troughs in China's population curve and solely consider the peaks*), population growth was exceedingly sluggish—glaringly slower than during the final few centuries BC! (*From the Western Zhou Dynasty to the dawn of the Common Era, China's population likely tripled*).

Japan exhibited the exact same pattern. Compared to the rapid population growth from the Yayoi period to the Nara period, population growth from the Heian period to the early Sengoku period was monumentally slower.

As Europe ushered in the **High Middle Ages** in the 11th century, another massive wave of land reclamation and population growth commenced. Japan's population similarly experienced a massive surge at the dawn of the Edo period (*which to a certain extent proves that Japan's **feudalization** process lagged temporally behind Europe's*). However, I will not delve into that discussion here.

Second, **The Great Expansion** violently impacted antiquated social consciousness. Within a protracted era of constant transformation, novel ideas and concepts gradually materialized. This constitutes its most paramount ideological contribution.

By the year 1000 BC, the history of human civilization was already immensely ancient. Back then, when the inhabitants of Egypt gazed upon the monuments of Giza, or when the inhabitants of Mesopotamia looked at the crumbling ruins of Ur, it was exceedingly difficult for them to possess any lucid historical memory regarding the epoch when these structures were actually built. For thousands of years, the paramount characteristic of the world people observed was enduring stagnation. A constellation of city-states dotted the civilizational map; occasionally, a formidable monarch would expand his territory to forge a kingdom, which would inevitably decay after a few generations.

There existed a few mercantile city-states along the western seaboard; agricultural production in Anatolia was notoriously unstable; and roaming the lands further east, north, and south were ephemeral nomads. Only Egypt stood as a long-lasting, unified nation-state, yet the fundamental social morphology of this regime remained highly rigid since its initial unification. Whether it was Asiatic invaders or the pharaoh who worshipped Aten (阿吞), all eventually faded into the dust of bygone eras. In Egypt, it seemed as though one dynasty was eternally followed by merely another dynasty; in Mesopotamia, royal authority merely seemed to perpetually transfer from one city-state to another.

The profound transformation brought about by **The Great Expansion** was not merely that people—having witnessed a vast new world—began to doubt the antiquated, stagnant dogmas and actively sought new interpretations of the world. More crucially, following victorious conquests over indigenous populations and massive geographical engineering of the environment, these conquerors began to contemplate and readjust their relationships with other entities—whether that be other humans, Nature, or elusive deities!

The unceasing victories in reality unequivocally served as a colossal psychological boost for the entire ethnic group. Therefore, in the final millennium BC, the peoples who partook in **The Great Expansion** universally grew far more confident. This newfound confidence was reflected in every conceivable facet of ideology and social behavior.

Deities began to transition from unpredictable, draconian, and punitive figures into relatively benign entities that could be approached and comprehended through certain means. From the Shang Dynasty to the Zhou Dynasty, the supreme deity worshipped by the Chinese underwent exactly this metamorphosis. Allegedly, the God of Judaism experienced a similar evolution: from the Old Testament to the New Testament, the image of God became phenomenally more compassionate. In the eyes of the Aryans in India, the gods were their primary vanguard in conquering the subcontinent.

The nature of divine sacrifices also underwent a radical transformation: practices that could potentially sabotage social production were drastically curtailed. In China, from whatever angle one examines it, there is a glaring distinction between the sacrifices of the Shang Dynasty and those of the Zhou Dynasty; from a modern perspective, the latter was undeniably more civilized. *(This can be effortlessly understood through logic: Before the Great Expansion, overpopulation was an inevitable trend. Human sacrifice, though utterly brutal, possessed a twisted underlying rationale. During the era of the Great Expansion, however, a surplus of manpower was virtually impossible; more labor directly equated to more wealth and greater power. Thus, the reformation of sacrificial rites was an absolute inevitability).*

In India, revulsion toward the convoluted, massive sacrifices of Brahmanism directly catalyzed the rise and dissemination of Buddhism and Jainism. In the Near East, Jewish devotees seeking atonement before God were required to offer substantial sacrifices; however, after Jesus allegedly bore immense suffering on behalf of humanity, Christians were no longer required to pay such exorbitant prices.

People believed in their own capacities and the efficacy of their choices more than in any previous epoch!

Zoroaster (琐罗亚斯德 / also translated as Zarathustra) emphasized human free will, insisting that people should exercise their own intellect and judgment to execute actions for which they are responsible, thereby driving the world toward an order of goodness.

The Greeks went the furthest. Achieving spectacular triumphs in philosophy, mathematics, and natural science, they believed humans possessed the capability to cognitively conquer the universe—and they succeeded astoundingly!

In China, regardless of the divergent doctrines championed by the Hundred Schools of Thought (诸子百家), the era where the Shang people trembled helplessly before *Shangdi* (上帝 / the Supreme Deity in ancient Chinese texts, not to be conflated with the Christian God) was entirely eradicated! When navigating relationships between humans and Nature, deities, or other peoples, the most conservative factions argued that letting Nature take its course would still yield a perfectly decent life. Meanwhile, the most radical factions were already roaring: "*Master the Mandate of Heaven and exploit it!*" (制天命而用之).

In summary, society adopted a phenomenally more proactive posture in embracing transformation across all dimensions.

This very metamorphosis would subsequently sculpt some of the most crucial—and to this day, profoundly nostalgic—characteristics of **classical empires**: *A spirit unconstrained by antiquated systems and daring to pioneer the world; an open and inclusive social ethos; the explosive rise of academies and schools of thought; a torrent of academic achievements; a volcanic eruption of new cultural and artistic forms; massive leaps in science and technology; and the widespread dissemination of rationalism.*

They glorified and illuminated the classical empires, forging a heroic age of triumph and glory!

Of course, once the expansion of the classical states reached its absolute limits and **feudalization** commenced, social consciousness rapidly pivoted in an entirely different direction, which I will discuss shortly.

Third, **The Great Expansion** shook the antiquated social structures to their core, challenging the status of humanity's earliest batch of rulers—the aristocrats, priests, and monarchs who had evolved from clan chieftains, shamans, and war leaders.

This is patently obvious: The Great Expansion entailed massive population migrations, the conquest of vast territories, and the erection of new cities. Prior to the modern era, it was fundamentally impossible for any regime to effectively control population mobility on such a colossal scale and scope. The population mobility during this period proportionately exceeded even that of the later colonial era (*after all, the total population was much smaller back then, but establishing permanent*

settlements likely required more raw manpower because the technological level during the Great Expansion was far more backward). This was especially true for highly mobile ethnic groups like the Aryans.

Even in China—where the Zhou Dynasty possessed a massive population base and even a relatively mature administrative system—the Huaxia Order (华夏秩序) spearheaded by the Zhou Emperor completely disintegrated by the 8th century BC! In that era, an unpopular person or faction within one city-state could easily flee into exile in another region and continue to propagate and implement their doctrines.

Nations with divergent political orientations competed fiercely, forging alliances and counter-alliances (合纵连横). For a remarkably long duration, no single regime was capable of subjugating its peripheral neighbors, resulting in the formation of a highly pluralistic geopolitical paradigm.

The power of the old-guard rulers was systematically eroded during this process; the only variable was the specific manifestation of their decline presented to the world. In Greece, monarchs were highly likely to be directly overthrown, leading to the establishment of republics or aristocracies. In China, usurpations where "minor lineage branches replaced major lineage branches" (小宗取代大宗) and "ministers usurped their sovereigns" (卿士取代国君) occurred repeatedly.

The loosening of the old order triggered mutations across the entire social structure. The power of conservative factions—or, to put it more bluntly, reactionary factions—was massively crippled. They no longer possessed the capacity to stifle the emergence of novel elements. In India, the rigid caste stipulations of the Vedic period began to falter once the classical era commenced; a person's status became increasingly dependent on their secular achievements rather than their caste.

And as we shall soon see, when classical empires were eventually established, monarchs—driven by their own self-interest during the initial stages of **feudalization**—would invariably lean toward supporting the newly emerging minor landlords and rich peasants, cultivating them to suppress the old aristocracy. **This sequence of changes forged the fundamental political prerequisites for feudalization.**

Why must we place such immense emphasis on the destruction of original political structures caused by the Great Expansion?

The reason lies here: Out of the two monumental macro-stage transitions human society has experienced to date, the transition from a slavery society to a **feudal society** is vastly different from the transition from a **feudal society** to a capitalist society!

Even ignoring the much later completion of the Industrial Revolution, simply by observing the *onset* of the Industrial Revolution, anyone would be astounded by the explosive growth of Britain's fiscal revenues in the 18th century. This means that when a **feudal society** transitions into a capitalist society, the capitalist system exhibits colossal superiority from the very beginning! Today, it is easy to notice that nations where the bourgeoisie was strongest and first established bourgeois democratic regimes (like the Netherlands and Britain) rapidly achieved dominance in global competition, projecting national power utterly disproportionate to their territory and population size.

Logically, this is not difficult to comprehend. After all, the vigorous development of capitalist elements directly equates to vibrant economic activity. As long as the state does not perceive this mutation as a threat or find itself utterly incapable of utilizing it (*a difficulty that ceases to exist*

once the bourgeoisie seizes power), economic development yields nothing but absolute benefits! The augmentation of fiscal revenues enters a virtuous cycle, and the ensuing surge in national power is entirely unsurprising. As for the immense advantages brought by modern scientific and technological innovations, they merely give wings to tigers (如虎添翼) for nations that seized the initiative in social development.

However, the process of advancing from an early state, through a classical empire, and finally reaching the feudal stage is entirely diametrically opposed!

In its initial stages, **feudalization** inherently signifies the establishment of the dominance of a **natural economy** (自然经济), the decay of cities and commercial activities, a social ethos growing increasingly conservative, and the frequent eruption of civil wars and foreign invasions. As I have mentioned numerous times previously, this process was initially intensely anxiety-inducing and terrifying for the people living through it—just like the people in the late Heian period (平安后期) muttering all day long that the "Age of Dharma Decline" (末法时代 / Mappō) had arrived. Yet Japan's situation was already remarkably fortunate; after all, it suffered no foreign invasions. No matter how the samurai marched on Kyoto (上洛), they were still Japanese!

Consistent with people's pessimism, early **feudal states** indeed did not necessarily possess any advantage over **classical empires** in terms of overall national power (*especially regarding the most intuitive metric: military strength*). From **Late Antiquity** to the dawn of the High Middle Ages, technological progress was exceedingly limited. The organizational capacity of these regimes had not yet recovered to classical levels, and their metrics regarding territorial expanse, population, and fiscal revenue were phenomenally inferior to the past.

It is precisely this superficial "decay" during the collapse of classical empires that forged the most severe and enduring ideological illusion in human history! It buried fundamental historical truths beneath the dust of time. Yet, if we merely brush away the surface layer of dust, we will discover that the evidence is absolutely ubiquitous. **Puncturing this grand illusion is one of the primary reasons I am writing these words!**

Therefore, the transition from a **feudal society** to a capitalist society is infinitely easier than the transition from an **early state** to a **feudal society**. As long as a nation's bourgeoisie can emerge onto the political stage independently (*rather than under external influence or subjugated by a bureaucratic system*), modernization is merely a matter of time.

Conversely, the arduous obstacles and profound uncertainties involved in evolving from a **feudal landlord class** into **feudal lords** firmly controlling the state are staggeringly immense! We observe that the overwhelming majority of nations utterly failed to smoothly traverse this stage (*in fact, prior to intense Western influence, only Japan managed to do so outside of Western Europe*). Some progressed agonizingly slowly, some stagnated for millennia, and **China simply derailed entirely from the normal developmental trajectory of human society!**

Thus, the shaking of the old order prior to the dawn of the classical era undeniably possessed a certain "historical righteousness" (历史正义性 / it was conducive to social progress). This is inversely corroborated when we observe Egypt, the Indus Valley, and Mesopotamia—the three former core regions of human civilization that, under the rule of their primary civilizations, possessed zero energy to execute the Great Expansion. As we shall see next, **feudalization** emerged

exceedingly late in all three of these regions, a phenomenon that appears staggeringly abrupt when contrasted with their highly developed agricultural production levels!

Of course, we cannot rule out another possibility: agriculture heavily dependent on irrigation networks along the banks of major rivers is genuinely detrimental to the emergence of **feudalization**.

This is indeed a plausible explanation, and it is corroborated by isolated evidence in regions with analogous environments. The Niger River bend region, as discussed in the previous chapter, plunged into severe decay following the collapse of the Songhai Empire and exhibited no considerable **feudal characteristics**, ultimately surrendering the leadership of **feudalization** in the Sahel region to the Fulani people two centuries later.

Floodplain agricultural zones along the banks of massive tropical rivers seem to possess an overwhelmingly strong inertia for maintaining a smallholder economy (小农经济). They struggle even to develop the **manorial economy** (庄园经济) characteristic of early **feudalization**. Perhaps this is genuinely because the former is simply more efficient under those specific agricultural conditions.

I once believed the banks of the Nile upstream of Egypt served as a similar example. The several Christian kingdoms within modern-day Sudan conspicuously lacked **feudal characteristics** right up until they were fundamentally annihilated by Islamic regimes around 1500 AD. They even retained prominent matriarchal characteristics in their inheritance systems! (*This perfectly explains why, despite both being Christian enclaves, Sudan was conquered by Islam after resisting for eight or nine centuries, whereas a **feudalized** Ethiopia remained staggeringly resilient and even launched counteroffensives!*) The Funj people (芬吉人) who eventually dominated Sudan also remained merely nominal Muslims for a very long time (see previous chapter).

But evidently, my understanding of the world outside China is still limited. I now know that the extent of flooding above the First Cataract of the Nile (尼罗河第一瀑布) is quite narrow, fundamentally insufficient to form the production mode dominated by floodplain agriculture seen in the Egyptian region below the First Cataract. In the so-called Nubia region, the Nile acts more as an elongated oasis; moving just a short distance from the river, the landscape rapidly transitions into a mixed agro-pastoral zone (农牧混合带). Under these specific conditions, the sluggishness of local **feudalization** is indeed unsurprising, but it cannot be categorized under the floodplain agriculture typology.

Regardless, Egypt and Mesopotamia indeed collapsed on the path toward a **feudal society**; they could never again play leading roles on the international stage. This is perhaps a form of historical destiny: **conditions highly favorable in one epoch may mutate into decisively unfavorable ones in another**. It is akin to how the territory of the modern United States was undeniably exceedingly inhospitable to agricultural production during the pre-industrial era, yet in our current age, it is more than sufficient to incubate the world's supreme superpower.

There is another issue worth noting here. Although it has become customary in our nation to refer to **early states** as **slavery societies** (奴隶制国家/社会), in reality, **it was precisely the historical process of The Great Expansion that pushed slavery—or rather, physical human possession and the coercive exploitation of labor—to its absolute zenith!**

The reasons are essentially twofold: First, the voracious thirst to continuously develop new land summoned an astronomical demand for labor, transforming human laborers into highly coveted commodities. Second, wars of conquest inevitably reduced massive multitudes of the defeated into slaves.

Thus, we observe that during the late Roman Republic, the number of independent yeomen (自耕农) plummeted drastically, while a massive influx of slaves into Rome triggered the explosive development of the slave economy. This, in turn, precipitated various political and military reforms—some successful, others not. In the even earlier Greek world, whether in Athens or Sparta, the slave population vastly outnumbered the citizens! Even for the Aryans, before they settled in their newly conquered lands, class differentiation might not have been distinctly pronounced.

The situation in China remains somewhat opaque, simply because the academic debate over whether slavery actually existed in ancient China has become heavily politicized in our nation. However, there remains undeniable evidence proving that slavery expanded phenomenally during the period of **The Great Expansion**. In the bronze inscriptions (金文) of the Shang Dynasty, we strictly see records of rewarding currency (*cowrie shells*), but no records of rewarding human populations. Yet, in the bronze inscriptions of the Western Zhou Dynasty, there are voluminous records of rewarding, buying, and selling human populations!

I firmly believe that China's evolutionary trajectory in this regard should be entirely consistent with that of other regions.

While we previously heavily emphasized the monumental role played by pivotal technological innovations like bronze and iron, we must bear in mind that technology itself does not inherently dictate social mutation as a direct, standalone factor. After all, it is *humans* who apply the technology and wield the tools!

Constrained by objective natural conditions, certain technologies that universally trigger massive social structural shifts might completely fail to induce such changes under specific circumstances. When this occurs, the actual efficacy of the technology is phenomenally discounted.

Regarding the historical process of **The Great Expansion**, the most crucial metrics must be:

1. Reaching the societal organizational level of an **early state** (*rather than remaining as overly backward tribal societies*); and
2. Possessing a definite capacity to subjectively engineer and transform the environment (*rather than merely migrating and searching for new pre-existing settlements*).

If these two prerequisites are not satisfied, the expansion becomes exceedingly difficult to differentiate from humanity's primitive early migrations, and is utterly insufficient to forge a **classical state**. (*Some might suggest including long-distance trade as a metric, but I believe this is unnecessary. Once the above two conditions are met, there is no logical reason for commercial factors not to emerge. Therefore, adhering strictly to Occam's Razor, I will not unnecessarily multiply entities*).

For instance, we can observe the Bantu expansion (班图人扩张) and the Austronesian expansion (南岛人扩张) that similarly occurred in history. The geographical expanses they impacted were undeniably vast, and their transformative effects on local societies were undeniably profound. When the Bantu people conquered the southern half of the African continent, they had already mastered

iron smelting; when the Austronesians conquered the Pacific, their navigational technology was astonishing.

However, regarding the former, Africa's natural environment was atrociously hostile to agricultural societies—resources were hyper-dispersed, and diseases ran rampant. The Bantu expansion was primarily conducted through primitive social morphologies like tribes or **tribal confederacies** (部落联盟), while the indigenous peoples in the regions they conquered were even more backward, lacking even the most rudimentary agricultural production skills.

Regarding the latter, although the Austronesians established **early states** on islands like Pohnpei (波纳佩岛) and Tonga (汤加岛), and constructed massive monumental architecture, certain technologies (*such as metal smelting*) were permanently lost during their migrations. After all, securing a stable supply of mineral ores across the boundless expanse of the Pacific Ocean is an absolute impossibility! When the ocean serves as an impenetrable natural barrier, let alone in antiquity, even today humanity's capacity to engineer it remains insignificantly minuscule. With inhabitants scattered across tiny, isolated islands, the very land they stood upon was phenomenally precious. Under such constraints, what could they genuinely transform?

As for the concepts of Aryans (雅利安人) and Indo-Europeans (印欧人)... due to the catastrophic devastation wrought by Nazi Germany's aggression in the 20th century, contemporary discussions about these groups are inevitably heavily contaminated by the influence of "political correctness" (政治正确).

There constantly exist discourses that excessively belittle the prowess and achievements of the Aryans, going so far as to assert that an organized invasion was "impossible," and that the expansion of Indo-European languages was merely the result of neighboring peoples "peacefully adopting" the new language. **This is glaringly an overcorrection of monumental proportions** (矫枉过正)!

Although the Indo-European expansion was unequivocally not the conquest of a monolithic "Indo-European Empire" executed under a unified will, organized, long-distance invasions orchestrated by specific Indo-European tribes were absolutely, 100% possible!

Such examples occurred explicitly in our own nation's history. The ancestors of the Bamar people (缅甸族)—the dominant ethnic group in modern Myanmar—were Qiang people (羌人) who originally inhabited Northwestern China. They migrated southward along the eastern fringes of the Tibetan Plateau, ultimately reaching the Irrawaddy River basin (伊洛瓦底江流域) today, traversing a staggering distance of nearly 2,000 kilometers!

In the latter half of the **first millennium AD**, the density of ethnic group distribution to the west and southwest of China was significantly higher than during the era of the Aryan migrations, especially since **classical empires** like *Nanzhao* had already emerged. Yet, the unassailable fact we observe today is that the Bamar people firmly occupied the middle and lower plains of the Irrawaddy River, possessing a nation that, while struggling to govern its frontiers, still encompasses a remarkably large territory!

The expansion of the Zulu Kingdom (祖鲁王国) in the early 19th century further obliterates this "peaceful migration" myth. Under the leadership of a **Charismatic leader** like Shaka (恰卡), the aggression of the Zulu Kingdom, coupled with the encroachment of Europeans and climate shifts,

forced myriad surrounding tribes into massive migrations—the furthest reaching all the way to the Great Lakes region! This geopolitical upheaval stimulated the genesis of the Kingdoms of Lesotho and Eswatini (斯威士兰). It forced multitudes of people to migrate thousands of kilometers, traversing vast latitudinal spans across Southern Africa—a region possessing an environment vastly more hostile than Central Eurasia.

In terms of technological capabilities, the Black populations of South Africa in the early 19th century were no superior to the Aryans of antiquity. Yet, they similarly executed massive, large-scale migrations accompanied by armed invasions!

Therefore, if the Indo-Europeans possessed critical technological resources that granted them monumental superiority—such as horses and chariots (马匹和马车)—and mastered the smelting and utilization of metal tools through interactions with peripheral peoples, executing widespread invasions under the command or coercion of one or more **Charismatic leaders** was entirely, unequivocally possible!

Furthermore, the surviving literature from the Vedic period in India blatantly oozes the "**arrogance of the conqueror**" (征服者的傲慢). From absolutely any analytical angle, this renders the notion that the Indo-Europeans entered India via "peaceful evolution" (和平演变) utterly preposterous!

6, 大扩张在古典帝国形成中的巨大意义

第一, 大扩张使社会免于陷入马尔萨斯陷阱, 确保了劳动生产率的稳步增长, 这是最重要的经济贡献。在金属工具被广泛使用之前, 文明世界的居民如同身处汪洋大海般的孤岛中一样, 能够稳定提供各类产品剩余的城邦在上千年的时间里相当固定, “良田美池”的范围世代代皆认为如此。这不是说在大扩张之前早期文明就全然没有改造自然, 扩大农业用地的能力, 古埃及人也在一直试着开发法尤姆绿洲 (Faïyum)。但是这种开发显然属于原本地理单元边缘的零敲碎打, 既不能改变本文明所面临的地缘格局, 也不足以有效疏解人口压力。无论是美索不达米亚还是埃及, 它们在公元前最后一段时间丧失独立性之前都经历了不止一次破坏性极大的社会危机, 如埃及的第一中间期, 至于美索不达米亚的农业经济条件在苏美尔晚期就已经衰退了, 土地盐碱化十分严重。还有一个更惨的印度河文明, 在雅利安人还没有到来之前就已经消失, 城市被放弃, 大概也是环境恶化使然。孤岛中的居民们不是完全不能跑, 他们当然有机会加入周边的部落中去, 但是这会使得他们不再被视为文明世界的成员。诚如马尔萨斯所言, 一直到现代科学出现, 工业革命开始之前, 技术进步只是零星出现, 生产力不会发生最近两个多世纪这样的爆炸性增长。在资源充足的情况下, 人口却会以指数级增长。这意味着任何零星的生产力提高都会被人口增长所平抑, 社会陷入一种在近些年被称为“内卷” (involution) 的状态, 劳动生产率难以实质性地增加, 社会成员的生活水平没有得到改善, 在有的时候还会变得更糟。

大扩张在几个世纪内终止了这种危险, 因为对于那些参与了这个历史进程的族群来说, 一旦社会的人口出现剩余, 或者因为气候变化出现了区域性的农业危机, “剩余人口”可以通过向远处迁移开拓新的文明世界求得生存。社会生产的进步不会再被人口增长所平抑, 因为只要有的选择, 过上了更好日子的人有什么理由回到更糟糕的时候去? 实际上人们如果注意到希腊人当年派遣有几个儿子的家庭抽签选择一个儿子前往殖民地, 就不难意识到大扩张对于疏解人口的巨大意义。人口增长在这个时候反而是个好事, 有多少人就足以开拓多大的疆土, 无需担心农业回报率和生活水平回落。扩张带来的人口流动以及人口激增、族群之间碰撞交流、新资源产地的发现都可能会刺激商业活动变得更加繁盛, 并且对技术革新有正向的推动作用。正是在古典帝国建立前几个世纪的劳动生产率虽然不快但是持续稳定的增长奠定了古典繁荣的基石, 社会财富的增加创造出了远比扩张之前多的脱产知识分子, 催生了一大批革命性的新思想、新科学、新技术, 为更加复杂的国家机构形成提供条件。

这种迅速的扩张进程没有一直持续下去, 自从古典帝国扩张到其最大边界直到中世纪盛期开始 (我在叙述的时候, 将中世纪等同于封建时期, 中世纪盛期等同于封建中期), 这几个世纪中的土地开垦虽然一直没有停止, 但是由于自然经济的发展和政治组织能力的弱化 (当然, 这绝非坏事), 其效率远不能跟古典社会形成期的扩张相比。人口 (当然还包括人口背后的已垦耕地大小) 变化充分反映了这一点,

从公元 150 年到公元 1000 年间，无论是正常封建化的欧洲还是最终完成官僚复辟的中国（让我们忽略我国人口曲线那悲惨的谷底，只考虑一个峰值）人口增长都十分迟缓，显著慢于公元前的最后几百年，从西周年间到公元前后，中国的人口可能翻了三倍。日本的情况也一样，比起弥生时代到奈良时代的快速的人口增长，从平安时期到战国前期的人口增长就慢了很多。随着欧洲在 11 世纪迎来中世纪盛期，新一轮大规模的开垦和人口增长进程开始了，日本人口也在江户初期迎来了大幅增长（这在一定程度上说明日本在封建化进程上晚于欧洲），不过这里我不予讨论。

第二，大扩张冲击了旧有的社会意识，在一个长期变化的世界中，新的思想和观念逐渐形成，这是最主要的思想贡献。在公元前 1000 年的时候，人类文明的历史已经很久远了，当年的埃及居民看吉萨（Giza）的遗迹，美索不达米亚居民看乌尔（Ur）的残垣断壁，也很难对于这些建筑修建的年代有清晰的历史记忆。千百年来，人们看到的世界是以长久不变为主要特征的，星罗棋布的城邦点缀着文明的版图，偶尔会有强大的君主扩张成为一个王国，随后几世而衰。西方的海滨有一些贸易城邦，安纳托利亚的农业生产不稳定，更东更北更南的地方是飘忽不定的游牧民。只有埃及是一个长久的统一民族国家，但这个政权的基本社会形态自首次统一以来相当稳定，无论是亚洲的入侵者还是崇拜阿吞（Aten）的法老都成为陈年往事。在埃及，似乎一个王朝之后总是有下一个王朝；在美索不达米亚，看起来王权总是从一个城邦转移到另一个城邦。

大扩张带来的变化不仅仅是人们在见识了广阔的新世界之后开始怀疑旧的，缺少变化的观点，转而寻求对世界的新解释。更重要的是，随着在征服过程中对于原住民的胜利以及对环境的大幅改造，这些征服者们开始思考并调整自身与其他角色的关系，不管是其他人，自然，还是难以捉摸的神灵。现实中的节节胜利无疑对整个族群的心态起到了巨大的鼓舞，因此在公元前的最后一个千纪，经历了大扩张的人民在总体上变得更加自信，这反映在意识形态和社会行为的方方面面。神灵开始从不可测的，严厉和惩罚性的形象，转变为可以通过某些办法接近并认识，相对温和的形象。从商代到周代，中国人崇拜的最高神就发生了这样的变化。据说犹太教里的上帝也是类似，从《旧约》到《新约》，上帝的形象变得慈爱了许多。在印度的雅利安人看来，诸神是他们征服次大陆的主力。对神的祭祀也发生了转变，对于社会生产可能造成破坏的行为减少了。在中国，商朝的祭祀和周朝的祭祀无论从什么角度看都有显著差别，后者站在现代人的观点更加文明（这一点可以通过逻辑很容易理解，在大扩张之前人口过剩是一种必然的趋势，杀人祭祀虽然残忍但是有其道理。在大扩张时期，人力几乎不可能过剩，劳动力越多就意味着财富越多力量越强，对祭祀进行改良是必然的）。在印度，对于婆罗门教繁琐的，大规模的祭祀的反感促进了佛教和耆那教的兴起和传播。在近东，犹太教的信徒要想在上帝面前赎罪需要献上不少祭品，不过在耶稣为大家承受许多苦难后，基督徒便不需要付出这么大代价。

人们比以往任何一个时候都更相信自己的能力以及自己做出的选择的作用。琐罗亚斯德

（Zoroaster，也翻译成查拉图斯特拉）强调人的自由意志，强调人们应该经过自己的思考和判断，做出需要自己负责的行为，并应使世界向善的秩序运动。希腊人走得最远，他们在哲学、数学和自然科学上成就非凡，他们相信人能够认识世界并且取得了惊人的成功。在中国，无论诸子百家各自持什么观点，像商朝人那样面对上帝（这里是中国古代文献中的上帝不是基督教的那个）战战兢兢无能为力的时代都过去了。在处理人与自然界，神灵和其他人的关系上，最保守的派别认为顺其自然过小日子也能过得很好，而最激进的派别已经在高呼“制天命而用之”。总而言之，社会在各个方面都采取了一种更加积极的态度去迎接变革。这种变化将在日后塑造古典帝国的一些最重要的，并且令人们怀念至今的特征：不拘于旧制敢为天下先的精神，社会风气开放包容，学院和学派兴起，学术成果涌现，文化艺术新形式井喷，科学和技术大幅进步，理性主义广泛传播。他们为古典帝国增光添彩，塑造了一个光荣和胜利的英雄年代。随着古典国家的扩张达到尽头以及封建化的开始，社会意识迅速转向另一个方向，这个等下再谈。

第三，大扩张动摇了旧有的社会结构，使得人类最早一批统治者，那些从氏族首领，萨满和战争领袖演变而来的贵族、祭司和君主的地位受到了挑战。这一点显而易见，大扩张意味着人口的大量流动以及征服广大地域，新的城市建立起来。在近现代之前，不可能有任何政权有能力对如此规模和范围的人员流动进行有效地控制。这一时期的人口流动从比例上超过后来的殖民时期（毕竟人口总数要少很多，但是建立永久定居点需要的人力可能更多，因为大扩张时期的技术水平要落后），对于像雅利安人这样移动性很强的民族就更是如此了。即使在中国，周朝的人口基数本身就大，甚至还有比较成熟的管理体制的情况下，到公元前八世纪的时候由周天子主导的华夏秩序也解体了。一个城邦不受欢迎的人或团体，

在那个年代很容易流亡到其他地方，并且继续宣传和贯彻其主张。不同政治倾向的国家一同竞争，合纵连横，在相当长的时间里，没有哪个单一政权能够压倒周边的政权，形成了一种多元化的格局。老牌统治者的权力在这一过程中被削弱了，无非是以何种面目呈现于世而已。在希腊，很有可能君主直接被推翻，建立了共和制或者贵族制；在中国，小宗取代大宗，卿士取代国君的事发生了多次。旧秩序的松动使得整个社会结构发生了变化，保守势力，或者说难听一点，反动势力，的力量被大幅削弱，他们不再有能力去遏制新因素的产生。在印度，吠陀时代严格的种姓规定在古典时期开始后也发生了动摇，一个人的地位更多取决于其取得的世俗成就而非种姓。而我们马上就会看到，当古典帝国建立起来的时候，君主出于自己的利益在封建化的最初阶段往往会倾向于新兴的小地主和富农，扶植他们来打压贵族。这一系列变化为封建化提供了基本的政治条件。

我们为什么要强调大扩张对于原有政治结构的破坏呢？原因在于，在人类社会发展到今天为止所经历的两次大的阶段过渡中，从奴隶制社会到封建社会的过渡与从封建社会到资本主义社会的过渡差别很大。即使不考虑到工业革命完成那么晚，仅仅观察到工业革命开始的时候，任何人都不会对18世纪英国财政收入的高速增长而感到惊叹。这也就是说，当封建社会向资本主义社会过渡的时候，资本主义体制在最初就表现出了巨大的优势，人们今天很容易注意到资产阶级最强大，最先建立资产阶级民主政体的国家迅速在竞争中取得了优势，展现出了与其领土和人口不相匹配的国力，比如荷兰和英国。这在逻辑上也不难理解，毕竟资本主义因素的蓬勃发展意味着经济活动的活跃，只要国家不将这种变化视为威胁或全然无法利用（资产阶级已经掌权就不存在这个困难），那么经济发展对其可谓百利无害，财政收入的增加会进入一个良性循环，国力强盛也就不足为奇。至于近代科学技术革新所带来的优势那就使得在社会发展上取得先机的国家如虎添翼。

但是从早期国家经由古典帝国到达封建阶段这个过程完全不同，封建化在最初意味着自然经济取得主导地位，城市和商业活动出现衰退，社会风气日益保守，内战和外族入侵频繁。就如我之前已经提到过多次，这个过程在一开始是令当时的人感到极为焦虑和恐惧的，就比如平安后期的人们整天念叨着末法时代已经来临。然而日本的处境已经相当不错，它毕竟没有经历外族入侵，武士再怎么上洛那也是日本人。与人们的悲观相一致的是，早期封建国家在国力（尤其是最直观的军事力量）上确实未必对于古典帝国具有优势，从晚期古典到中世纪盛期开始，技术进步还十分有限，政权在组织能力上还没有恢复到古典水平，而从疆域、人口和财政上看就更加大不如前。恰恰是古典帝国崩溃时期这种表面上的“衰退”，制造了人类有史以来在观念上最为严重，最为持久的幻象，将一些基本事实掩盖在历史尘埃里，哪怕我们只要刷掉表面的一层灰就会发现证据简直无处不在，戳破这一幻象，也是我写下这些文字最主要的目的之一。

因此从封建社会向资本主义社会的过渡要远远易于从早期国家向封建社会的过渡，只要本国的资产阶级能够独立地（而不是在外部影响下，或受制于官僚体制）出现在政治舞台上，近代化就是早一点还是晚一点的事。而从封建地主阶级发展为坚定统治国家的封建领主其中的艰难险阻和不确定性太多了，我们看到，绝大多数国家都没有顺利越过这一阶段（在被西方强烈影响之前，其实除了西部欧洲只有日本一个地方做到了）有的进展缓慢，有的长期停滞，中国则直接脱离了人类社会的正常发展轨迹。因此在古典时代开始前动摇旧秩序确实有一定的“历史正义性”（有利于社会进步），这在人们观察埃及，印度河，以及两河地区这三块在原生文明统治下，没有精力大扩张的，曾经的人类文明核心地区时得到了反向的印证。接下来我们会看到，这三个地区的封建化出现得都非常迟，与当地发达的农业生产水平相较之下显得极为突兀。

当然，我们也不能排除这样一种可能，也就是大河两岸依赖于灌溉网络的农业确实不利于封建化的产生。这也是一种可能的解释，并且在环境相似的地区得到了个别证据的支持。上章就讨论过的尼日尔河曲地区在桑海帝国覆灭之后也陷入了严重的衰退，没有出现可观的封建化特征，把萨赫勒地区封建化的领导权让给了两个世纪后的富拉尼人。热带大河两岸的洪泛农业区似乎具有非常强的保持小农经济的惯性，甚至难以发展出封建化早期的庄园经济，或许真的是因为前者在特定的农业条件下更具效率。我曾以为在埃及上游的尼罗河沿岸也是同样的例子，现在苏丹境内的几个基督教王国直到1500年前后被伊斯兰政权基本消灭为止都缺少封建化的特征，甚至在继承制上都保留了显著的母系特征（恰恰说明为什么同样作为基督教的飞地，苏丹在抵抗八九百年之后被伊斯兰教征服了，但是封建化的埃塞俄比亚却如此坚挺甚至进行反击），入主苏丹的芬吉人（Fung）在很长时间内也只是表面的穆斯林（见上章）。但很明显，我对于中国以外的世界了解的还不多，现在我知道尼罗河第一瀑布以上洪水泛滥的范围很小，

不足以形成第一瀑布以下埃及地区以泛滥农业为主的生产模式。在所谓的努比亚地区，尼罗河更多扮演了一个长条状的绿洲角色，在离河很近的地方就演变出了农牧混合带。这种条件下当地封建化的缓慢确实不足为奇，却不能归为泛滥农业的类型。无论如何，埃及和美索不达米亚确实倒在了通向封建社会的路途中，他们再也不能在国际舞台上扮演主要角色了。这或许也是一种宿命，在一个时期有利的条件得到另一个时期可能就转为不利，好比今天美国的领土在前工业时代确实对于农业生产太不友好了，但是在我们这个年代，它足以孕育一个世界头号强国。

这里还有一个值得注意的问题是，虽然在我国把早期国家称为奴隶制国家，已经成为习惯，但其实真正把奴隶制或者说人身占有和强制剥削劳动力推向顶峰的正是大扩张这个历史进程。原因无非是两点，首先是继续开发土地的渴望呼唤更多劳动力，这使得劳动力成为人们趋之若鹜的商品，其次是征服战争必然使得失败者大量沦为奴隶。所以我们看到在罗马共和国晚期自耕农急剧减少，大量奴隶涌入罗马使奴隶制经济迅速发展，这导致了一些或成或败的政治和军事上的改革。在更早一些的希腊世界，无论是雅典还是斯巴达，奴隶的数量都远多于公民。雅利安人在新征服地定居之前，阶级分化都未必明显。中国的情况不清楚，因为中国上古时期的奴隶制存不存在这个问题在我国已经相当政治化。不过还有一些证据证明奴隶制在大扩张时期发展了，商代金文中只见到赏赐货币没有看到赏赐人口，但是西周金文中存在大量赏赐买卖人口的记录，我认为中国的变化应该与其他地区一致。

虽然我们之前非常强调青铜和铁这样重要技术革新起到的作用，但还是应当注意技术并不作为直接影响的因素对社会变动起到作用，毕竟应用技术，操作工具的总是人。在客观的自然条件限制下，一些普遍能够引起社会结构大幅变化的技术在特定情况下不一定引起变化，这个时候它的实际功效就大打折扣。就大扩张这个历史进程而言，最重要的指标应当为达到早期国家社会水平（而非过于落后的部落社会）以及有一定能力主观改造环境（而不仅仅是出走并寻找新的定居点）。如果不满足这两点，这种扩张就难以和人类早期的扩张相区分，不足以缔造古典国家（或许会有人提到长途贸易，但我认为没有必要，因为上面两点满足之后没道理商业因素还不出现，因此根据奥卡姆剃刀原理就不再增添）。

例如我们观察到历史上同样出现过的班图人扩张和南岛人扩张，它们影响的地理区域不可谓不广泛，对当地社会的改变不可谓不深远。班图人在征服南部半个非洲的时候已经掌握了冶铁技术，南岛人在征服太平洋的时候航海技术令人印象深刻。然而对于前者而言，非洲的自然环境对于农业社会太不友好，资源分散，疾病肆虐，班图人扩张时主要以部落或者部落联盟这样原始的社会形态进行，而他们征服地区的原住民只能更为落后，甚至连最原始的农业生产都并未掌握。对于后者而言，南岛人虽然在波纳佩岛和汤加岛建立了早期国家，也修建过大型奇观建筑。一些技术却随着迁徙而失传，例如金属冶炼，毕竟在茫茫太平洋上获得稳定的矿石供应是不可能的。大海作为自然屏障，不要说在当年，即使是现在人们改造它的能力依然显得过于渺小，居民被分散在一个个小岛上，他们能够立足的土地都是弥足珍贵的，又能够改变什么呢。

至于雅利安人以及印欧人这两个概念，因为 20 世纪纳粹德国侵略所造成的巨大破坏，现在人们谈到它们免不了受到政治正确的影响。总有一些言论过度贬低雅利安人的实力及其成就，甚至认为有组织的入侵是不可能的，印欧语的扩张是印欧人周边的民族和平接受新语言的结果，这显然太矫枉过正了。虽然印欧人扩张肯定不是“印欧帝国”在一个统一意志下进行的征服行为，但是一些印欧人部落进行有组织的长途入侵是完全可能的。我国历史上就发生过这样的例子，今天缅甸的主体民族缅族的祖先是生活在中国西北地区的羌人，他们沿着青藏高原的东缘向南迁徙到了今天的伊洛瓦底江流域，行程将近 2000 公里。公元第一个千纪的后半段，中国西侧及西南侧的民族分布的密度怎么都要比雅利安人迁徙的时候多得多，毕竟像南诏这样的古典帝国都出现了。现在我们看到的事实是，缅甸人稳稳占据了伊洛瓦底江中下游的平原，拥有一个虽然对于边疆难以管理，但是仍然面积不小的国家。

至于 19 世纪初祖鲁王国的扩张更加说明了这一点，在恰卡（Shaka）这样一个卡里斯玛式领袖的帶領下，祖鲁王国，欧洲人的逼近和气候变化迫使周边的许多部落进行迁徙，其中最远地到达了大湖地区。这场运动刺激了莱索托王国和斯威士兰王国的产生，使许多人民迁徙上千公里，并且是在环境恶劣比欧亚大陆中部恶劣得多的非洲南部地区跨越纬度运动。从技术水平上讲，19 世纪初的南非黑人也不强于当年的雅利安人，但是他们一样完成了大范围的迁徙并且伴随着武装入侵。因此如果印欧人拥有马匹和马车这样使自己具有重要优势的技术资源，在与周边民族的交流中掌握金属工具的冶炼和使用，在一个或者不止一个卡里斯玛式领袖的指挥或者逼迫下进行广泛的入侵是完全可能的。而且现在残留下来的印度

吠陀时期文献明显表露出了征服者的傲慢，这使印欧人进入印度从任何角度都不像是通过“和平演变”实现的。